JS8FastChat Instructional Guide Ver 1.76

To install, download JS8FastChat from github.com/mjordan501/JS8MapChat/releases. Install instructions are in the JS8FastChat README there (Windows and Linux) and in “Installing JS8FastChat on Linux” in its docs folder.

1 What this Guide Covers

This guide explains what each control in JS8FastChat does. It assumes the program is already installed and talking to JS8Call. If it is not, follow the install instructions in the JS8FastChat README on GitHub, or “Installing JS8FastChat on Linux”, first — **nothing here will make sense until the two programs are connected.**

FastChat does not replace JS8Call. It sits beside it and puts the things that normally take a right-click and a menu onto single buttons. Most operators shrink the window and park it over the JS8Call waterfall so both are visible at once, which is what the picture below shows.

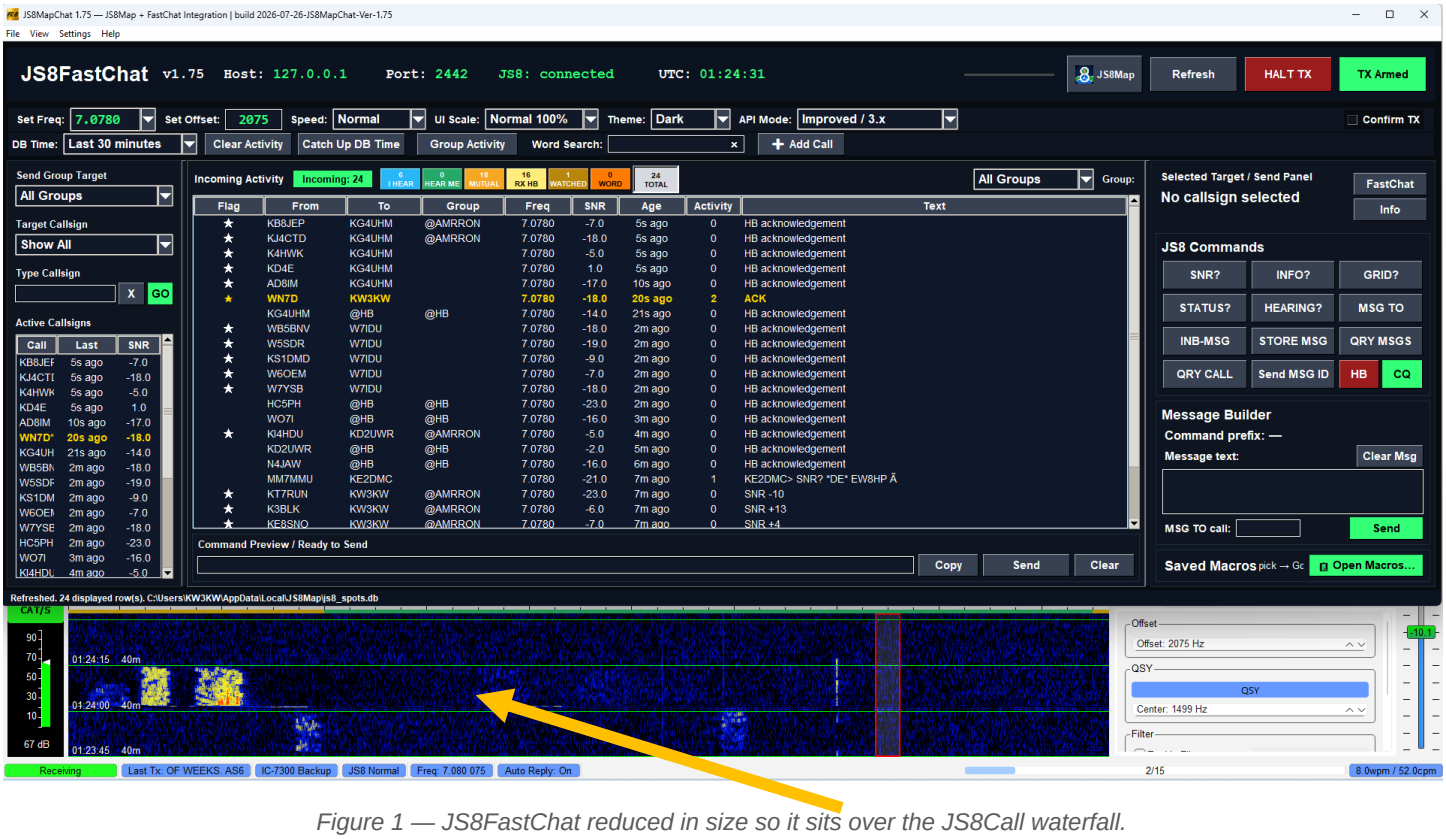


Figure 1 — JS8FastChat reduced in size so it sits over the JS8Call waterfall.

Note: Hover tooltips on every control in this application.

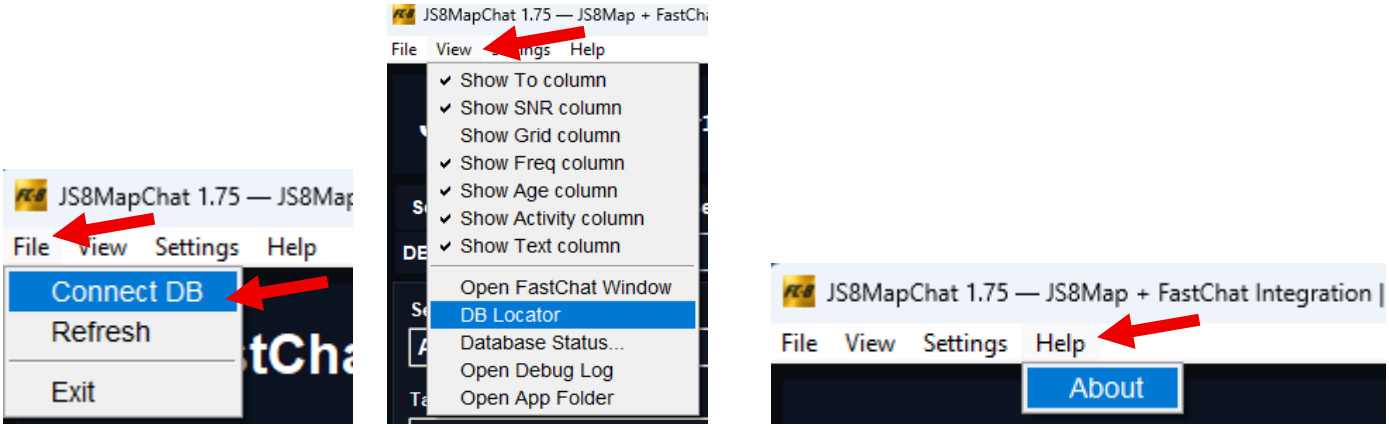
2 The Menus

Three menus sit above the header.

File — reconnects to the callsign database, refreshes the data FastChat has pulled from JS8Call, and closes the program. Closing FastChat does not close JS8Call.

View — turns each column of the activity list on or off, opens a FastChat window for the highlighted station, and holds the database tools — DB Locator, Database Status, the debug log, and the application folder.

Help — shows which version you are running.



Figures 2, 3 and 4 — The File, View and Help menus.

3 The Header

The header runs across the top of the window and carries the controls you reach for most often, along with the line that tells you whether JS8Call is actually connected.

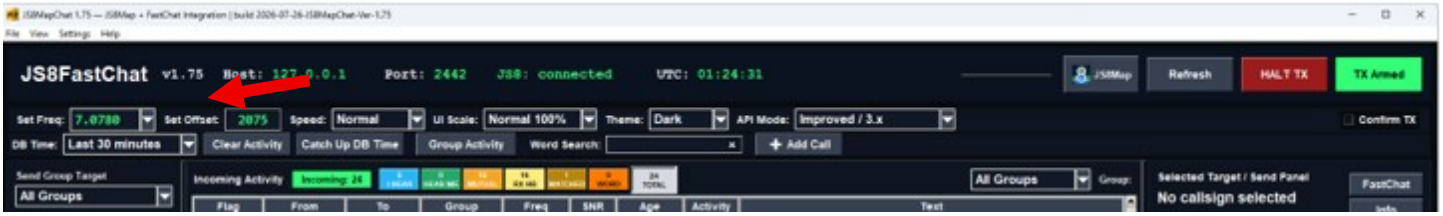


Figure 5 — The header, across the top of the window.



Figure 6 — The header buttons: JS8Map Spotter, Refresh, HALT TX, TX Armed, and the Confirm TX tick.

- JS8Map Spotter – brings JS8Map Spotter to the front with a single click.
- Refresh – refreshes the lists now, without waiting for the next automatic refresh (set in your settings).
- HALT TX – with JS8Call Improved (the 3.x API), stops a transmission from FastChat without going to the JS8Call screen.
- TX Armed – Green means the system is set to fire over to JS8Call
    - Checked Confirm TX – requires you to approve each command that is sent over to JS8
    - Unchecked Confirm TX – auto sends all commands to JS8Call as if you did it in JS8 itself

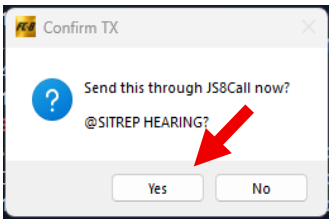


Figure 7 — Confirm TX. With the box ticked, every command waits for your approval before it reaches JS8Call.



Figure 8 — The status line: version, host, port, connection state and the UTC clock.

4 Filters and Dropdowns

The second row decides two things: what FastChat sends to JS8Call, and how much of the incoming traffic it shows you. These settings take effect immediately.

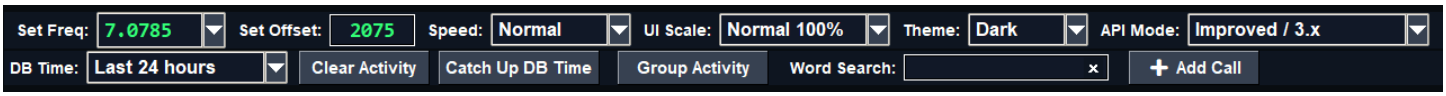
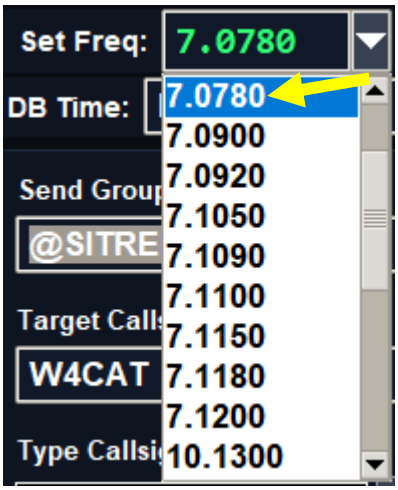
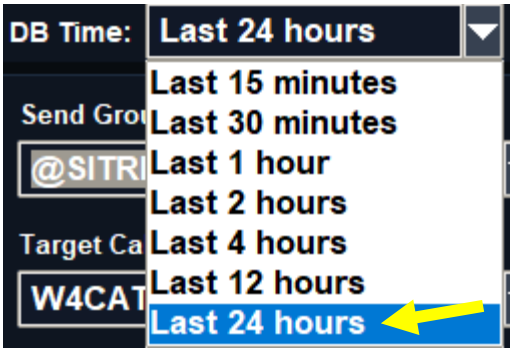


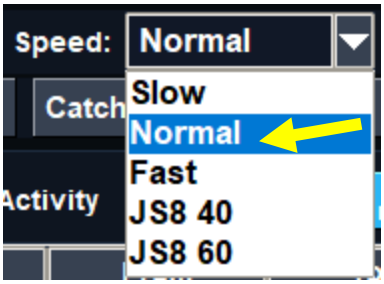
Figure 9 — The filter and dropdown row.





Figures 10 and 11 — Set Freq picks from the band list. Set Offset can be typed straight into the box.







Figures 12, 13 and 14 — DB Time, JS8Call speed, and the display theme.

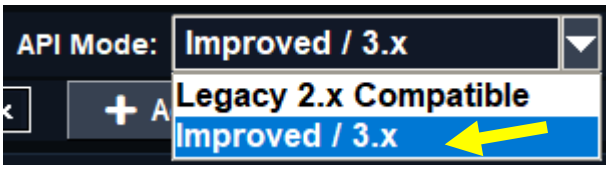


Figure 15 — API Mode. Legacy 2.x Compatible, or Improved 3.x.

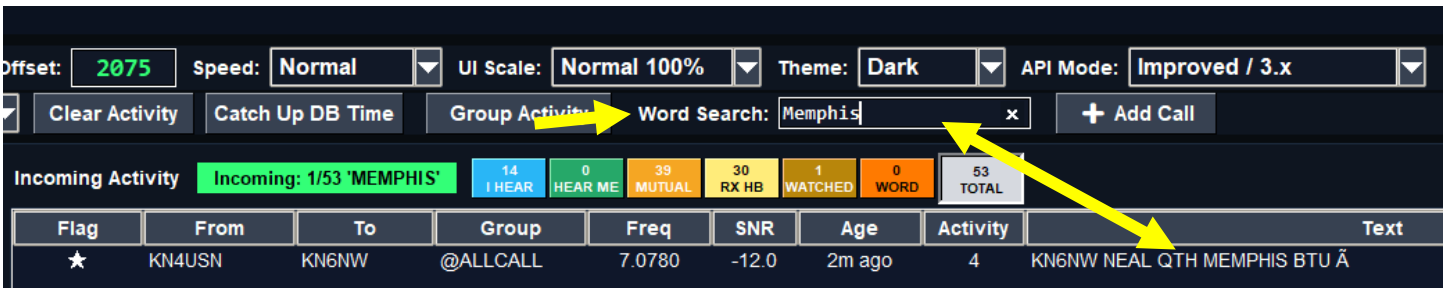


Figure 16 — Word Search.

Note: Word search only applies to current info in the main FastChat window. You can do a complete word search, to each individual callsign, under the History tab. See History section for more info.

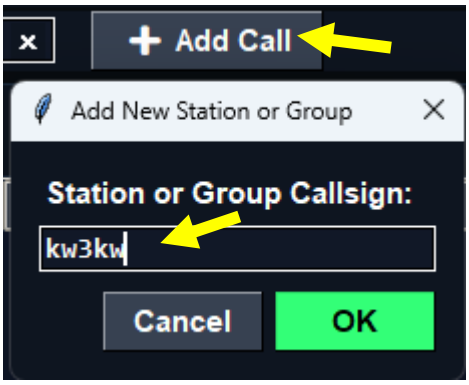


Figure 17 — Add Call. Adds a station or a group that JS8Call is not showing.

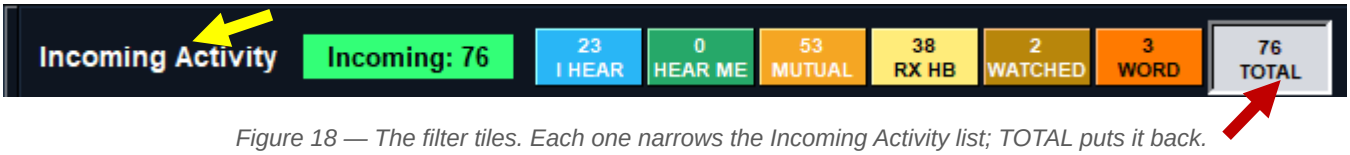


Figure 18 — The filter tiles. Each one narrows the Incoming Activity list; TOTAL puts it back.

Press a tile to filter the list. Click TOTAL to return to the full list.

5 The Left Side of the Screen

The left column is where you choose who a command is aimed at, and it gives you a second, quieter view of who is active without disturbing the main activity list.

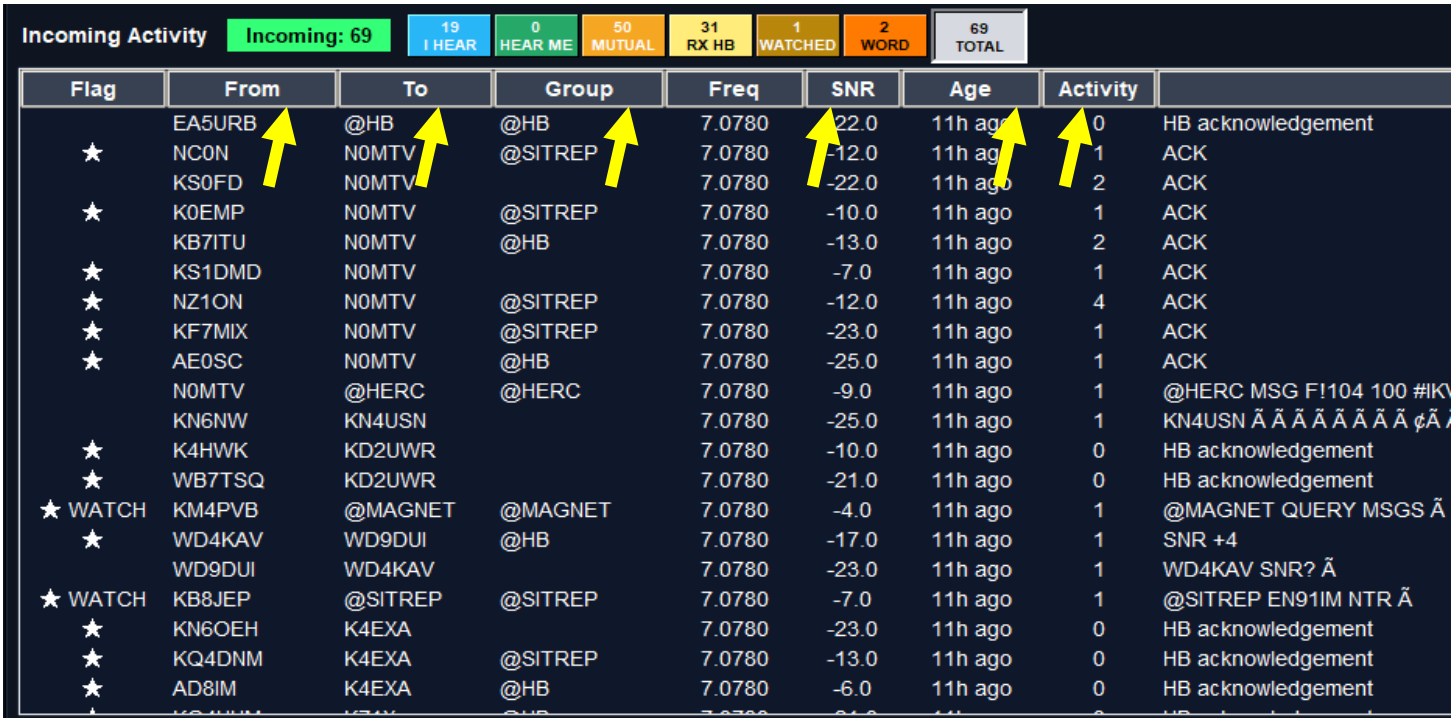


Figure 19 — The left side: send group, target callsign, type callsign, and the Active Callsigns list.

- Group Dropdown to SEND JS8 commands to a selected group
- Targeted Callsign – to send JS8 commands to a specific callsign
- Type Callsign – selects callsign on Current Activity screen – **X to clear the highlighted callsign on Current Activity screen**
- Active Callsigns header – Call, Last or SNR sort list for that box only. Second way to look at activity quickly without changing the main Incoming Activity screen

6 The Incoming Activity window

The middle of the window is the live activity list. Every decode JS8Call hands over appears here. This is the screen you watch, combining the three JS8 windows into one view. Fast sort capability built-in.



Flag	From	To	Group	Freq	SNR	Age	Activity	
	EA5URB	@HB	@HB	7.0780	22.0	11h ag	0	HB acknowledgement
★	NC0N	N0MTV	@SITREP	7.0780	-12.0	11h ag	1	ACK
	KS0FD	N0MTV		7.0780	-22.0	11h ag	2	ACK
★	K0EMP	N0MTV	@SITREP	7.0780	-10.0	11h ago	1	ACK
	KB7ITU	N0MTV	@HB	7.0780	-13.0	11h ago	2	ACK
★	KS1DMD	N0MTV		7.0780	-7.0	11h ago	1	ACK
★	NZ1ON	N0MTV	@SITREP	7.0780	-12.0	11h ago	4	ACK
★	KF7MIX	N0MTV	@SITREP	7.0780	-23.0	11h ago	1	ACK
★	AE0SC	N0MTV	@HB	7.0780	-25.0	11h ago	1	ACK
	N0MTV	@HERC	@HERC	7.0780	-9.0	11h ago	1	@HERC MSG F!104 100 #IK
	KN6NW	KN4USN		7.0780	-25.0	11h ago	1	KN4USN Ã Ã Ã Ã Ã Ã Ã Ã ¢Ã
★	K4HWK	KD2UWR		7.0780	-10.0	11h ago	0	HB acknowledgement
★	WB7TSQ	KD2UWR		7.0780	-21.0	11h ago	0	HB acknowledgement
★ WATCH	KM4PVB	@MAGNET	@MAGNET	7.0780	-4.0	11h ago	1	@MAGNET QUERY MSGS Ã
★	WD4KAV	WD9DUI	@HB	7.0780	-17.0	11h ago	1	SNR +4
	WD9DUI	WD4KAV		7.0780	-23.0	11h ago	1	WD4KAV SNR? Ã
★ WATCH	KB8JEP	@SITREP	@SITREP	7.0780	-7.0	11h ago	1	@SITREP EN91IM NTR Ã
★	KN6OEH	K4EXA		7.0780	-23.0	11h ago	0	HB acknowledgement
★	KQ4DNM	K4EXA	@SITREP	7.0780	-13.0	11h ago	0	HB acknowledgement
★	AD8IM	K4EXA	@HB	7.0780	-6.0	11h ago	0	HB acknowledgement

Figure 20 — The Incoming Activity window

Choose which columns to show from the View menu. Each column header is a filter / sort button.

- **Highlight callsign row** and then double click to open FastChat Window

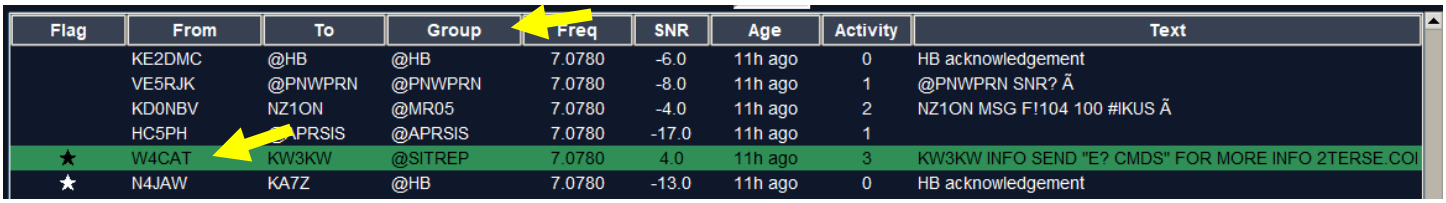


Figure 21 — Highlight a row, then double-click it to open that station's FastChat window.

7 The Right Side of the Screen

The right column acts on whichever callsign is highlighted in the activity list. Every JS8Call command is one button, and nothing is sent until you press it — or, with Confirm TX ticked, until you approve it as well.

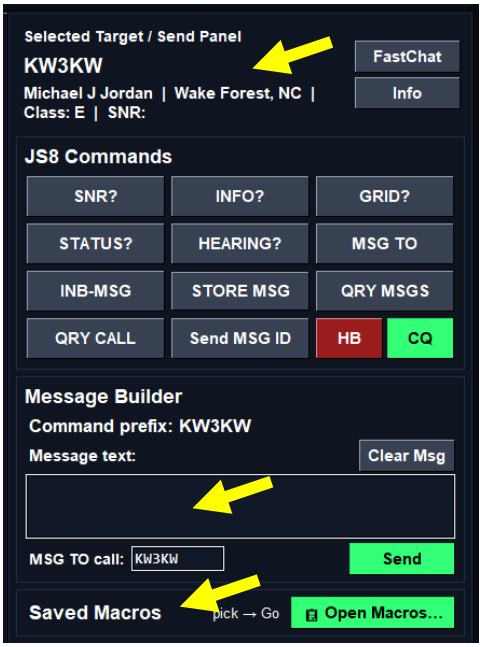


Figure 22 — The right side. Every JS8 command for the highlighted callsign, one click each.

JS8 Commands for HIGHLIGHTED Callsign.

- Secondary way to open the callsigns FastChat Window
- All key commands to auto send to JS8 with a single button click
    a. HB Button
    b. CQ Button
- Typing Box to send messages
- JS8 Macros for fast use commands
    a. Select and hit the ENTER key to send
    b. Select and hit GO to send

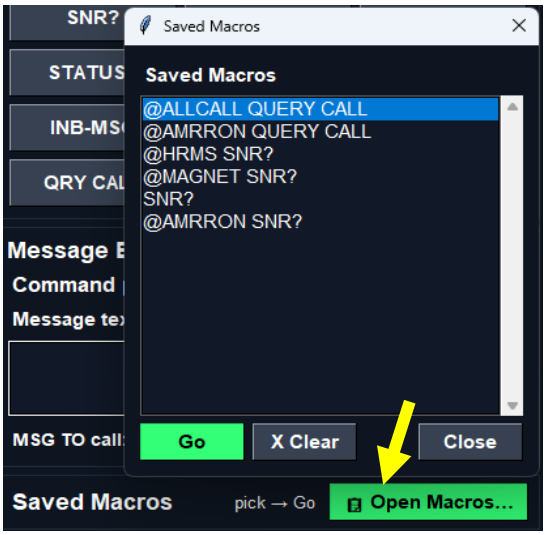


Figure 23 — Saved Macros.

8 The FastChat Popup Window

Main view to use in FastChat. To open, first highlight a callsign in the activity list. Next, double-click a station. The callsign you want to work with, gets its own window. This is where most operating actually happens, because everything to do with one operator is in one place.

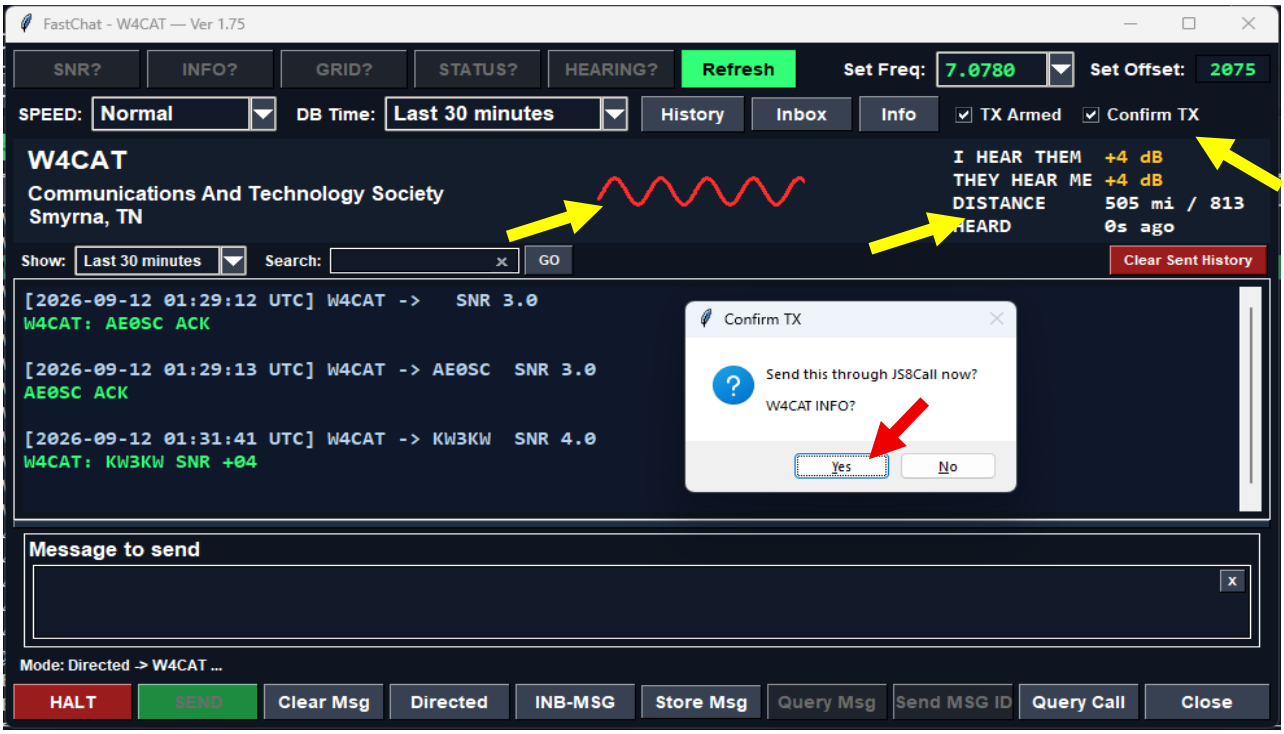


Figure 24 — A FastChat window, with Confirm TX waiting for approval.

- Many of the same key features as the main screen, but for one callsign. A single click uses any JS8 feature, without right-clicking or opening a list of options.
- Red sine wave indicates the rig is transmitting, and blocks all send functions until the transmission is complete.
- Allows for direct sending to JS8 or a confirmation popup for tighter TX control – Confirm TX
- Callsign operator name and information in one quick view
- SNR report for both ways – I Hear Them and They Hear Me

- Distance between you and them, Last Heard time
- Allows for key access to info
    - Inbox
    - Info (FCC Callsign DB Info)
    - History – shows their current activity for the session. Red font for history sessions.
        - **Other Traffic** – all activity for that operator and their contacts during the session. Allows you to see BOTH theirs and the RX callsigns activity in ONE view. Blue for other traffic sessions.

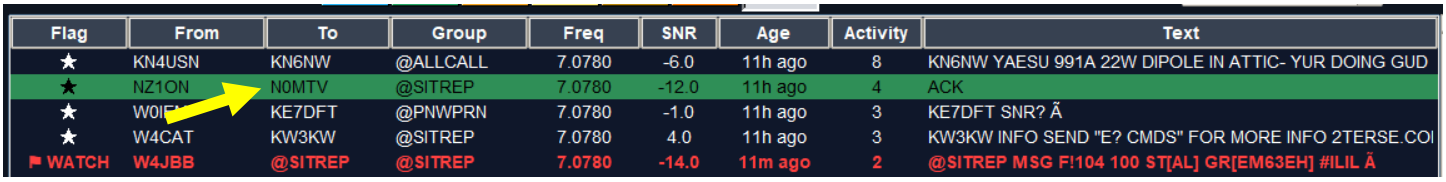


Figure 25 — Directed traffic highlighted in the activity list.

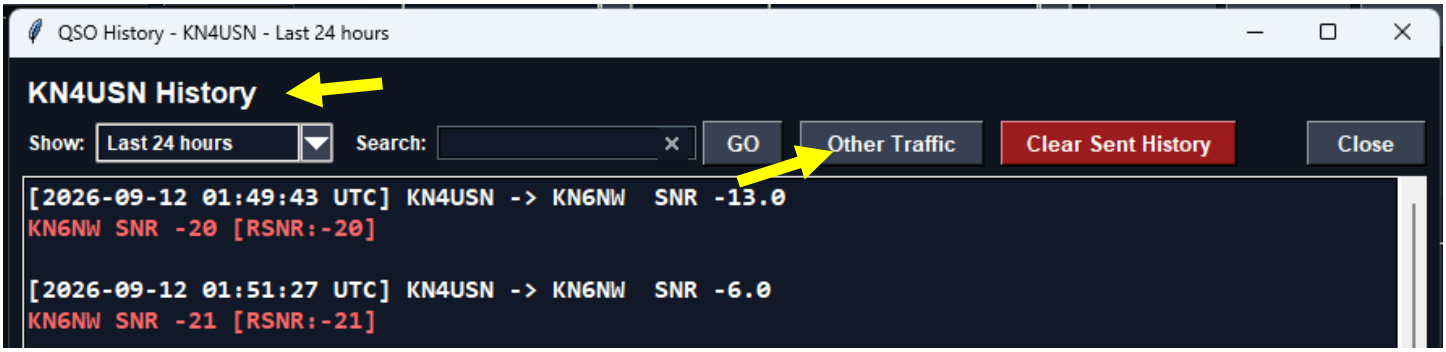


Figure 26 — History for a single station.

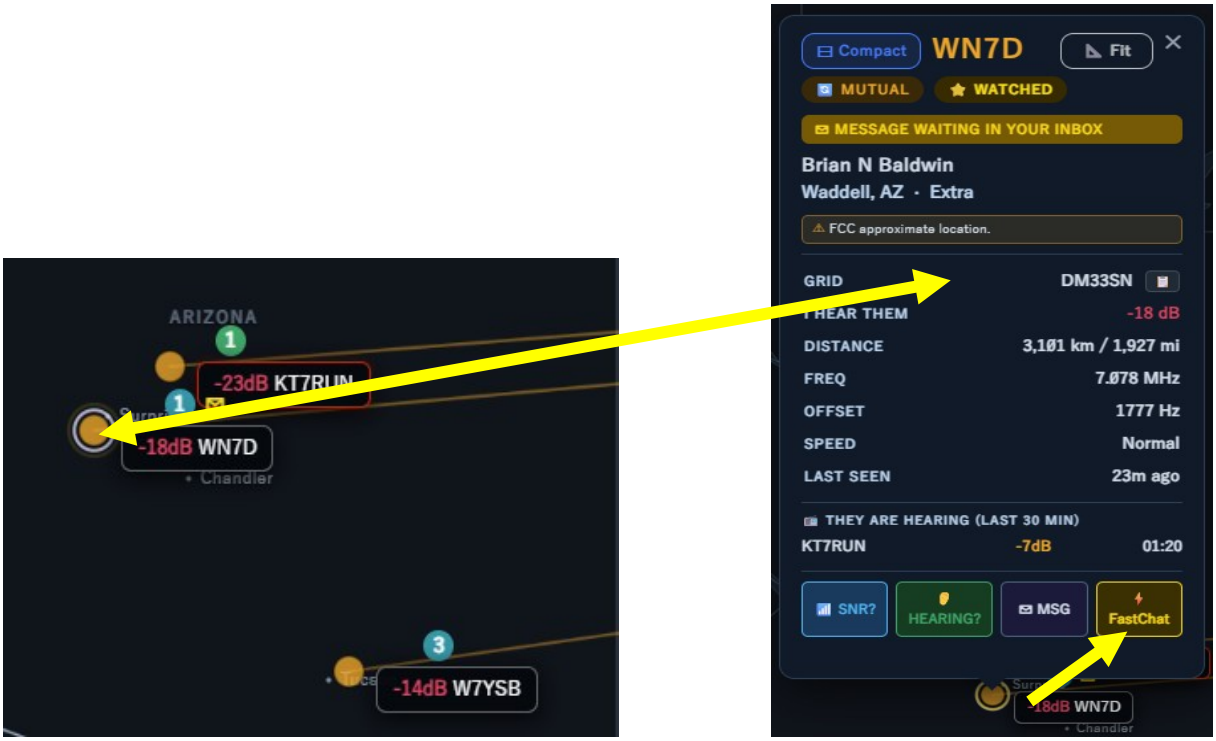


Figure 27 — Other Traffic: both sides of a conversation between two other stations.

9 JS8Map Spotter and JS8FastChat together

The two programs are linked in both directions, and this is the feature that makes JS8MapChat more than two tools that happen to share a folder.

- In JS8Map Spotter – select callsign dot and open up callsign popup
- Select the FastChat button and it opens the FastChat window for that callsign. Now use all the key features to make your experience a “Fast Chat” with your fellow operator.



Figures 28 and 29 — In JS8Map Spotter, click a station dot to open its popup, then click FastChat.

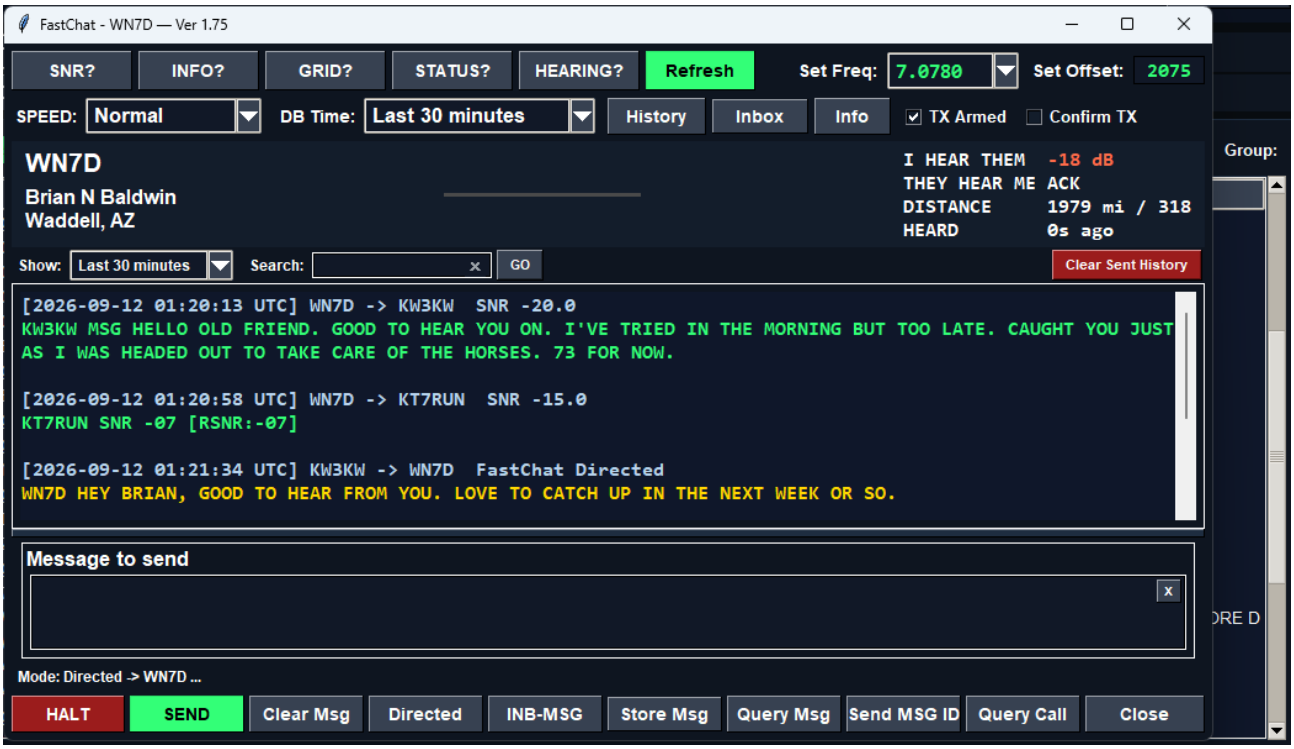


Figure 30 — The FastChat window that opens for that station.